Labor Relations in France, 1900: A Methodological Approach

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This paper aims to demonstrate the methodological approach taken to the dataset on French labor relations for the reference year 1900. This dataset was created for the Global Collaboratory on the History of Labor Relations, 1500-2000; this is a project of the International Institute of Social History to document labor relations worldwide and across time, to enable comparisons over the long-term and across the globe.

I. Data Selection and Digitization

In this section, I explain the selection of the data sources used to determine the labor relations, as well as the digitization required.

a. Selection

Since 1801, censuses have generally been carried out quinquennially. Of these many censuses I have selected one from 1906. The 1906 census is recognized as the most robust statistical reference from the beginning of the 20th century, according to Margaret Maruani and Monique Meron.[1] It is used throughout the literature on French occupational structure. Moreover, the 1906 census is best situated for any potential comparisons based on the dataset; it follows the norm for French censuses to categorize persons according to their industry, whereas, for example, the 1911 occupational census is exceptional in that it categorizes according to individual profession.[2]

Further, the selection of the 1906 census was also an issue of availability. A scan of the occupational data of the 1906 census was made available to me by Dr. Alexis Litvine.[3] Some of the historical censuses appear to have been, at most, partially digitized and made digitally available: the *institut national de la statistique et des études économiques* (French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies) (INSEE) has digitized some parts of the late 19th to early 20th century censuses, but these focus primarily on data related to age, sex, place of birth, literacy, etc., while the occupational data is left out. I have used these partial digitizations published by INSEE for the necessary non-occupational data.[4] In addition, I have used one table from Charles Rist and Gaëtan Pirou's *De la France d'avant*

[1] Maruani & Meron, 34.
[2] Rist & Pirou, 47.
[3] For which I am very thankful!
[4] INSEE, REC_T217, REC_T218, REC_T225.

guerre à la France d'aujourd'hui, that demonstrates the age distribution of the active population; this data is also taken from the 1906 census but could not be found elsewhere.[5]

b. Digitization

As the occupational data of the 1906 census was not yet digitized, I have had to do so myself (see **Appendix Table *A***). The digitization required me to enter all the occupational data and variables into Excel manually. I have for the most part only digitized the (two) highest levels of aggregation, as instructed by the dataset manual, and only included lower levels of aggregation for those industries that contain a variety of labor relations.[6]

At times it was necessary to reconstruct data that was not clearly visible, notably columns V15 (*isolées feminin* / female independent workers) and V16 (*établissements classés suivant le nombre des employés et ouvriers, ensemble* / enterprises categorized according to number of employees and workers, total):

V15 = V5 - (V7+V9+V11+V13)
V16 = V17+V18+V19+V20+V21+V22+V23+V24+V25+V26+V27+V28+V29

Additionally, I have calculated the categories at the highest levels of aggregation by summing those same categories of the second highest levels of aggregation, where possible. The calculations were then checked against the census counts to ensure that there were neither errors in the original census counts, nor in my digitization.

[5] Rist & Pirou, 86.
[6] Stapel, et al, "Codebook and Manual," 2.

II. Total and Economically Active Population

In this section I demonstrate how I obtained the numbers of the total and economically active population of France in 1906. It is important to note that the 1906 census of France is based on the 87 *départements* that France comprised of then, excluding most of the Alsace-Lorraine region and all the French colonies and protectorates (see Figure 1). France covered 53.646.374 ha.[7]



Figure 1. France, by its départements, 1910; the colonies inserted left were not included in the 1906 census. Source: BnF, France, par départements.

[7] INSEE, REC_T214, V111.

a. Total population

The total population of France is given by INSEE, as established in the 1906 census, as 39.252.245.[8] This number is comprised of two parts for each municipality: first, all people who usually reside in that municipality; second, all people currently residing in institutions in that municipality, such as military barracks, hospitals, schools, religious orders, etc.[9] This municipal population count does not double count persons, and is used as the French population count in statistical studies.[10]

This population figure for 1906 contains persons who are French-born and French-naturalized, as well as those without the French nationality.[11] It remains unclear, however, whether the census has only included persons legally residing in France, or also persons illegally residing in France.

Combining this total population and the occupational data of the 1906 census in the dataset, however, does open up danger to double counting. For example, one segment of the population that is enumerated apart, are *communautés religieuses* (religious orders). However, religious orders are already considered in the occupational data as *culte catholique (régulier)*, this group being Catholic clergy members who have taken to religious orders (as opposed to *culte catholique (séculier)*). Similarly, military personnel housed in barracks are counted apart as well, while the military is also included in the occupational data of the census under *services généraux* for the state. I have therefore only included those separately counted groups in the dataset when they presumably do not overlap with the occupational data, namely those groups that preclude labor (for the most part), such as people in prison, in hospital, and non-primary education.

b. Economically active population

The occupational data in the 1906 census is sorted along industry lines. The persons enumerated in the census are further categorized based on their situation within firms, namely as *chefs*, *employés*, or *ouvriers*. Those not working for a fixed employer are categorized as *isolés*. Those persons who are temporarily unemployed (less than one year) are categorized as *employées et ouvriers sans emploi*, but are still included in the industry counts for their profession. All these categories are further subdivided based on sex.

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[8] INSEE, REC_T214, V125.
[9] INSEE, "Municipal population."; INSEE, "Population counted apart."
[10] INSEE, "Municipal population."
[11] INSEE, REC_T218.

The census provides a basis to establish the total of economically active population (Table 1), as for each industry the total active population (and the subdivision based on sex) is given. This active population includes all categories for its industry mentioned above, namely employers, employees, workers, self-employed/independent workers, and the temporarily unemployed. Adding the active population counts per industry together provides a total active population, as well as the further subdivision of the male and female active population.

Employed or Temporarily Unemployed Population		
Total	**Men**	**Women**
20.720.879	13.027.467	7.693.412

Table 1. Economically active population in France as given by the 1906 census.

While child and female labor are often excluded from censuses, the 1906 census makes a step in mitigating this. This is due to the census enumerators incorporating any person living on a farm without occupation (schooling or work) as agricultural workers.[12] Still, only remunerated labor is included within the census, leaving out unpaid domestic labor.[13] Moreover, due to compulsory primary education, only people twelve and over are considered as being able to work in the first place. So, to determine the actual total population that was economically active, we must now turn towards child and female labor in particular.

i. Children aged five to twelve

While primary education was compulsory, this did of course not mean that no children under the age of twelve worked. Colin Heywood does note that by 1896 the reduction of child labor, especially that of children younger than twelve, was nearly complete regarding "[...] mines, ironworks, textile mills and factories of *la grande industrie*, in France as elsewhere in the West."[14] However, children continued to work outside of school hours and, in rural France specifically, school absenteeism continued to be a problem despite that schooling was mandatory.[15]

[12] Litvine, 49; Maruani & Meron, 35.
[13] Maruani & Meron, 34.
[14] Heywood, 149.
[15] Heywood, 149.

To incorporate this child labor, I have had to make some estimations, as this is neither included in the 1906 census nor does the literature provide such data. Interestingly, Maruani and Meron do infer the existence of child labor based on literacy rates: significant rates of illiteracy suggest that some children did not attend primary education, despite it being mandatory.[16] In that same vein, I have calculated the ratios of literacy and illiteracy of children younger than ten based on the absolute data from the 1906 census, digitized by INSEE.[17]

Literacy and illiteracy among children younger than 10		
	Girls	**Boys**
Literate children:	1.063.744	1.060.058
Illiterate children or children without declared level of education:	2.364.206	2.391.436
Percentage literate children of all children:	31%	31%
Percentage illiterate children of all children:	69%	69%

Table 2. Literacy and illiteracy among children younger than 10 according to sex, 1906.

As can be seen in the tables above, boys and girls have the same (il)literacy rates: 69% of boys and girls aged younger than ten years old are either illiterate or have no declared level of education, whereas 31% are able to read and write (Table 2). While these rates are of children up to nine years old, I have applied the same rates to children aged ten and eleven, as I assume that there would be no significant changes in literacy rates among children separated a couple of months or at most a couple of years.

Further, it is safe to assume that those children who are literate have attended a form of primary education and have not been absent from school to an extent that they were (regularly) working. Therefore, I have categorized the literate children as having labor relation 1, to indicate that they cannot (be expected to) work, as for the most part they were in school. On the other hand, the illiterate children and those without indicated education level

[16] Maruani & Meron, 35.
[17] INSEE, REC_T225, V85, V86, V89, V90.

have not attended primary education and must therefore have spent their time elsewhere. I assume that this time was spent working in some way. Based on Heywood's and Roland Caty's chapters on French child labor in *Child Labour's Global Past*, I gather that child labor was likely performed on family farms and in small-scale workshops or firms.[18] Therefore, I have categorized this group as 12a014, to indicate that they are employed in family enterprises or as wage earners in workshops. Although these working children were not taken to be part of the economically active population by the census enumerators in 1906, I have included them in my estimation of the economically active population.

ii. Structurally unemployed adults of working age

With all available data from 1906 that denote an occupation or reason for having no occupation included in the dataset, there continues to be a segment of the adult population that is structurally unemployed (Table 3. The remaining, structurally unemployed, population without defined occupation in the database.). By this I mean that they do not have a profession included in the census or have not had one for over a year.

Total population	39.252.245
Total population with defined occupation	30.546.965
Total remaining population without defined occupation	8.705.280

Table 3. The remaining, structurally unemployed, population without defined occupation in the database.

*For this group, the sex distribution is unknown, as while the occupational data specifies sex, the data on those persons in school, hospitals, or prison does not. To reconstruct this, I have calculated the ratio of male to female structural employment for those aged twelve to seventy years old, based on the data provided by Rist & Pirou on the age and sex distribution of employment (**Table 4**, and see*

Appendix Table *B* and **Appendix Table *C***).[19]

Structural unemployment, aged 12-69, according to Rist & Pirou			
	Total	**Men**	**Women**
Absolutes	8.758.100	1.817.900	6.940.200

[18] Heywood, 143, 149; Caty, 159.
[19] Rist & Pirou, 86.

Percentages	100%	20,8%	79,2%

Table 4. Absolute and relative structural unemployment, aged 12-99, according to Rist & Pirou.

I have applied this ratio to the persons who, after the inclusion of all occupational data, age data, and separately counted groups, remained without defined occupation, to roughly determine the ratio of men to women who are structurally unemployed (Table 5).

Structurally unemployed, aged 12-69, in Database	
Men	**Women**
1.806.936	6.898.344

Table 5. Estimations of structurally unemployed males and females in 1906 France, applying Rist & Pirou's sex ratios to the remaining persons without defined occupations.

The assumption underlying my estimation is that men and women are roughly equally incarcerated, hospitalized, and in schooling; this may not be entirely correct, but I lack the necessary data to make any other assumption. Moreover, even if this were not the case, the structurally unemployed would still skew heavily towards women.

As Maruani and Meron note, unpaid household labor is not represented in the census, as only remunerated work is counted as economic activity.[20] Due to this group being working age (twelve to seventy years old), it is likely that even while they were not employed in a paid occupation, they were performing labor in the household. This would explain the comparatively high number of women who are structurally unemployed, as women were historically more likely to be solely performing reproductive labor for the household. I have therefore categorized this group in labor relation 5: household kin non-producers who support the household through reproductive labor.

iii. Structurally unemployed adults over seventy

I have categorized structurally unemployed adults over seventy to be either not working or household kin non-producers (labor relation 105). I have chosen this cut-off point, as the rates for both men and women employed or only temporarily unemployed decrease significantly for the group over seventy.

[20] Maruani & Meron, 34.

Rate of employment and temporary unemployment, according to age group		
	Men	**Women**
Aged 60-64	85%	46%
Aged 65-69	78%	39%
Aged ≥ 70	57%	22%

Table 6. Percentage of men and women employed or temporarily unemployed, according to the highest age groups. Source: Rist & Pirou, see Appendix Tables B & C.

As can be seen in the table above (Table 6), in for both men and women the participation in remunerated work drops around twenty percentage points from the age group of 65-69 to that of ≥ 70. Such a steep decline in participation may indicate that many people in the latter age group have retired and/or are unable to perform (paid) labor any longer. However, many people over seventy clearly do continue to work, so it is not the rule that people over seventy were unable to work - as in fact the majority of men still performed paid labor. Moreover, the percentages of structurally unemployed adults over seventy may appear lower than they were, because of the exclusion of unpaid domestic labor from the data used. Therefore, I have decided to neither categorize this group as unable to work (labor relation 1), nor as household kin non-producers (labor relation 5), but as both (105), as either could be the case but it is not feasible to differentiate between the two groups (Table 7). Because of this classification, adults over seventy who are structurally without a paid profession would have to be included in the economically active population, as many perform reciprocal labor.

Structurally unemployed, aged ≥ 70		
Total	**Men**	**Women**
1.172.300	357.400	814.900

Table 7. Persons ≥ 70 who are structurally without paid employment.

iv. Conclusion: Economically Active Population

The economically active population of France in 1906, according to the definition of the Global Collaboratory, then consists of adults employed in remunerated work or only

temporarily unemployed, child labor, working age adults and adults over seventy performing reciprocal labor (Table 8).

	Total economically active population		
	Total	**Male**	**Female**
Adults in employed in paid labor or temporarily unemployed	20.720.879	13.027.467	7.693.412
Children ≤ 11, commodified labor	4.755.642	2.391.436	2.364.206
Adults 12-99, reciprocal labor:	8.705.280	1.806.936	6.898.344
Adults ≥ 70, reciprocal labor	1.172.300	357.400	814.900
Total economically active population	35.354.101	17.583.239	17.770.862

Table 8. Estimation of the total economically active population in France, 1906.

It must be kept in mind, however, that these are informed but still rough estimations of the economically active population. For many of these groups I have had to make assumptions about their performance of labor, which might mean that people have been incorporated who were not economically active, as well as that people might have been left out who were in reality economically active. Unfortunately, the unavailability of (reciprocal and commodified) labor data on some of these groups precludes more precise accounts of their economic activity.

III. Labor Relations

In this section, I will shortly elaborate on the assigned labor relations for unique or ambiguous categories.

a. Chefs

For *chefs*, I have used V16-29, the category sorting enterprises according to the number of people employed, to calculate the ratio of self-employed leading producers (labor relation 12a), employers (13), and those whose labor relation is unclear (12a013) (Table 9).

% self-employed leading producer (12a)	**% Employers (13)**	**% Unclear labor relation (12a013)**
(V17+V18) / V16	(V19+V20+V21+V22+V23+V25+V26+V27+V28) / V16	V29 / V16

Table 9. Formulas for calculating the percentages of 12a, 13, and 12a013.

While 12a is usually limited to those self-employed leading producers with fewer than three employees, I have had to expand this to five or less. This is because the census has categories for enterprises with no employees and with one to five employees, but no in between category denoting less than three. As production in France at the time was mainly performed in small and medium sized workshops (with the exception of some specific industries), leaving out this distinction between 12a and 13 would mischaracterize its occupational structure.[21]

b. Isolés

The category of *isolés* poses a unique problem for finding a specific, appropriate labor relation. As Maruani and Meron note, it is a particularly difficult category in general as it comprises a whole variety of workers: those who work from home at piece-rate, self-employed artisans, dayworkers, etc.[22] Therefore, it is difficult to distinguish, even within a singular industry, whether an *isolé* is closer to a self-employed leading producer or to a wage earner for the market at piece or time rate.[23] Where the occupational titles give an indication

[21] Heywood, 142.
[22] Maruani & Meron, 131.
[23] Maruani & Meron, 131-132.

of the appropriate labor relation for its *isolés*, I have applied that specific labor relation. For example, *métayers* are sharecroppers and have therefore been given the labor relation 141 and *apiéceurs de vetements* are pieceworkers and have therefore been given the labor relation 142. However, for many industries it cannot be inferred what the appropriate labor relation would be for its *isolés*. Moreover, the census excludes *isolés* from its category sorting establishments according to the number of people employed (V16-29) as well as from its category sorting employees and workers according to the number of employees/workers within their establishment (V30-35). As a result, it cannot be reconstructed what the employment situation is for *isolés*. Therefore, when their specific labor relation is unclear, I have categorized them as 12a014 to indicate this ambiguity.

c. Métayer

I have included *métayer* separately from its larger section of *culture*. As they are sharecroppers, they are explicitly categorized under labor relation 141. So, to accurately categorize both sharecroppers and non-sharecropping agricultural workers I have separated the former out.

d. Apiéceur and ouvroir

I have included *apiéceurs de vetements* and *ouvroir* separately from its larger section of *travail des étoffes*. As can be inferred from their title, *apiéceurs* are piece-rate workers and therefore have a specific labor relation that can be clearly differentiated from other textile and clothing workers. Here the same problem arises as discussed in the previous section on *isolés*, namely that it is unclear whether the non-*apiéceur* workers in this section could be piece-rate workers or not; their labor relation cannot be defined as clearly as that of *apiéceurs de vetements*.

Ouvroir were workshops set up by charities (such as orphanages) where girls and young women were made to sew clothing for department stores, so as to learn a trade.[24] These charities were often religious in nature and were exempt from the law.[25] It is unclear whether their student-workers earned a wage and whether their labor was free or unfree; this might have also differed between institutions. For now, I have categorized these workers as being wage earners employed by non-market institutions (labor relation 18), as (religious)

[24] Heywood, 146.
[25] Heywood, 146.

charities are not market institutions, but have not further specified their remuneration. It could, however, be the case that labor relation 15, indentured labor for the market, may be more appropriate if the women and girls in these *ouvroirs* were not freely employed (as presumably they did 'age out' of these charitable institutions).

e. Professions libérales

I have included the section *professions libérales* at its lowest level of aggregation in the dataset, as it contains a variety of labor relations. Specifically, it mixes labor for market and non-market institutions. So, in the subsection *professions judiciaires, huissiers,* who (depending on the specific meaning of the title) work for non-market institutions (the court or government), are grouped together with *avocats* and *notaires* who may work for market institutions. Similarly, in the subsection *enseignement, études, etc.* religious workers are grouped together with workers who work for market institutions, such as those employed by *écoles privées.* Additionally, regarding *professions médicales*, hospitals were either public or religious-based, which means that many of its employees worked for non-market institutions. But *pharmaciens*, who are also categorized in this subsection, may work in a firm, and thus work for the market. Therefore, it was most logical to include this entire section at its lowest level, to accurately differentiate between the appropriate labor relations.

f. Colonies agricoles

The category *maisons d'arrêt, de correction, centrales, et colonies agricoles* poses a problem for applying the taxonomy. *Colonies agricoles* are penal colonies for juveniles, where they were put to work in agricultural labor, but sometimes also received some form of primary education.[26] On the other hand, this category also includes those in jail and prison who may not work and would thus be most appropriately categorized as cannot work or cannot be expected to work (labor relation 1). However, it remains unclear what the ratio is within this category of those who must work and those who do not; I lack data on the ages of the individuals in this group in general, how many were in *colonies agricoles*, and how many had to perform unfree labor. As there is no generally accepted combination of labor relations that reflects this ambiguity between those imprisoned and unable to work and those imprisoned and forced to work, I have decided to categorize this group as having labor relation 1. This is

[26] Pierre, 1, 4.

neither fully accurate nor fully inaccurate, but there is no way to make this more precise with the data available.

IV. Balance of Labor Relations

I have compiled the labor relations in the database to provide an overview of the absolute and relative presence of the specific labor relations in 1906 France (

Labor Relation	Total	Percentage (of total labor relations)	Comments
1	5.488.026	13,98%	Unable to work
5	8.705.280	22,18%	Reciprocal household labor
105	1.172.300	2,99%	Unable to work / reciprocal household labor
12a	6.047.193	15,41%	Employers / head of enterprises: *chefs*
12a013	6.613	0,02%	
13	232.016	0,59%	
12a014	4.079.158	10,39%	*Isolés*
12b014	11.614.471	29,59%	Workers for market institutions: *employés*, *ouvriers*, and/or *isolés*
14	459.850	1,17%	
18	1.403.585	3,58%	Workers for the state or religious institutions / self-employed for religious institutions
12a018	693	0,00%	
12a014018	26.778	0,07%	
12b014018	16.282	0,04%	
Total:	39.252.245	100,00%	

Table 10). I have further grouped together related labor relations, to provide insight in the more general occupational structure (Table 11).

Labor Relation	Total	Percentage (of total labor relations)	Comments
1	5.488.026	13,98%	Unable to work
5	8.705.280	22,18%	Reciprocal household labor
105	1.172.300	2,99%	Unable to work / reciprocal household labor
12a	6.047.193	15,41%	Employers / head of enterprises: *chefs*
12a013	6.613	0,02%	

13	232.016	0,59%	
12a014	4.079.158	10,39%	*Isolés*
12b014	11.614.471	29,59%	Workers for market institutions: *employés*, *ouvriers*, and/or *isolés*
14	459.850	1,17%	
18	1.403.585	3,58%	Workers for the state or religious institutions / self-employed for religious institutions
12a018	693	0,00%	
12a014018	26.778	0,07%	
12b014018	16.282	0,04%	
Total:	39.252.245	100,00%	

Table 10. Balance of Labor Relations in Database.

Grouped Labor Relations	**Total**	**Percentage (of total labor relations)**
1	5.488.026	13,98%
5	8.705.280	22,18%
105	1.172.300	2,99%
12a, 12a013, 13	6.285.822	16,01%
12a014, 12b014, 14	16.153.479	41,15%
18, 12a018, 12a014018, 12b014018	1.447.338	3,69%
Total:	39.252.245	100,00%

Table 11. Balance of Labor Relations in Database, related labor relations grouped together.

In Table 11, workers for market institutions with labor relations 12a014, 12b014, and 14, comprised of *employés*, *ouvriers*, and *isolés* comprise the largest group by far. In contrast, the

number of people employed by non-market institutions, such as the state or religious institutions, are comparatively very few. The second and third largest groups are those performing reciprocal household labor (labor relation 5) and heads of enterprises or *chefs* (labor relations 12a, 12a013, 13). Such a large group of chefs may seem peculiar, but as can be seen in Table 10 small-scale enterprises indeed dominate in France, with nearly all *chefs* having labor relation 12a.

Appendix

Appendix Table A. Digitized occupational data, 1906 census France. Source: Statistique générale de la France, Tableau VII, pages 194-255.

Link to Excel Sheet of Appendix Table A.

Appendix Table B. Active population and total population, male, according to age, in thousands. *Source: Excerpt from Rist & Pirou, Tableau II, page 86.*

	Population Active[27]	**Population Totale**
12-17	1141,5	1932
18-19	553	622,6
20-24	1466,1	1555,4
25-29	1463,1	1522,3
30-34	1386,2	1432,2
35-39	1287,5	1531,2
40-44	1215,3	1259,5
45-49	1101,3	1153,6
50-59	1754,3	1911,2
60-64	674,3	791,7
65-69	487,3	623,5
≥ 70	481,1	838,5
Non declaré	16,6	292

Appendix Table C. Active population and total population, female, according to age, in thousands. *Source: Excerpt from Rist & Pirou, Tableau II, page 86.*

	Population Active	**Population Totale**
12-17	796,8	1920
18-19	389,4	637,2
20-24	955,6	1595
25-29	866,7	1553,6
30-34	783,5	1431,8
35-39	757,9	1366,7
40-44	708,7	1268,6
45-49	656,6	1188,7
50-59	1079	2050,3
60-64	396	855,6
65-69	281,9	717,2
≥ 70	236,2	1051,1
Non declaré	15	42,6

[27] This includes both those employed in paid labor and those temporarily unemployed.

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